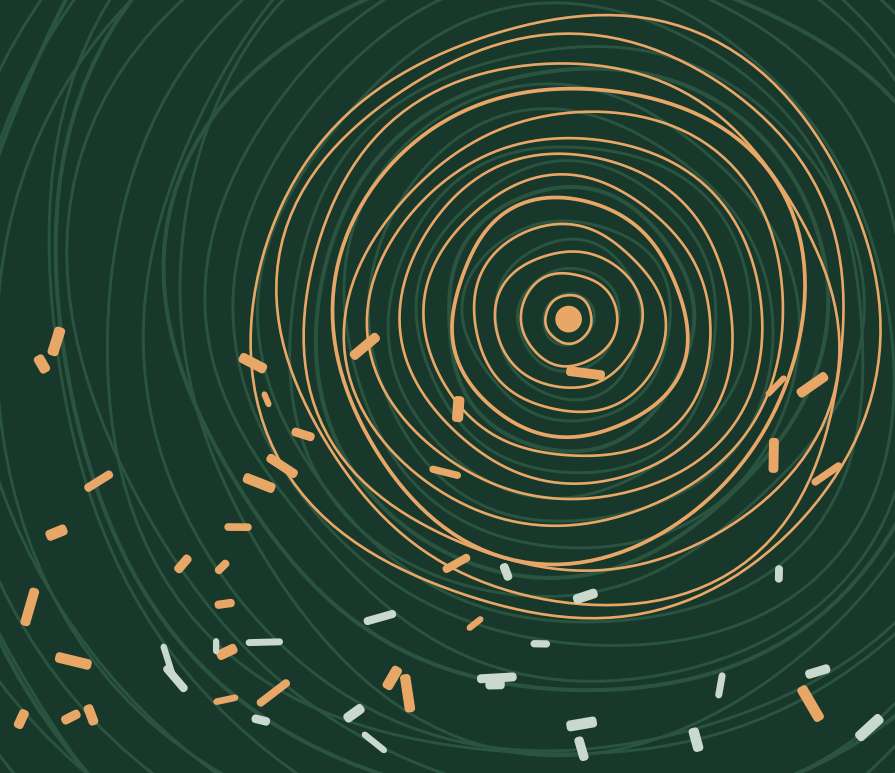
THE BEGINNER EDITION

The Stump Grinding Playbook

How to start a stump grinding business from zero: prove the demand, price it right, find the first jobs, and work safely.



Works with the Pricing & Business Calculator and the Templates & Scripts Pack

Prices and U.S. rules reviewed November 2026.

CONTENTS

What is inside

Start Here . . . 3

1. How Stump Grinding Makes Money . . . 5

2. Prove the Idea for Under $100 . . . 8

3. Set Up the Business . . . 11

4. Equipment and Startup Costs . . . 14

5. Safety . . . 18

6. Price It for Profit . . . 21

7. Land Your First Jobs: The Contractor Outreach System . . . 26

8. More Ways to Get Customers . . . 29

9. Quoting and Selling . . . 32

10. Doing the Job . . . 35

11. Upsells and Repeat Business . . . 38

12. Systems, Scaling, and Going Full-Time . . . 40

13. Your First Paid Job in 7 Days, and Your 30-Day Plan . . . 43

14. Running the Numbers: A Worked Example . . . 46

15. Common Questions and Beginner Mistakes . . . 48

Appendix A: Quick Reference . . . 50

Appendix B: Resources and Links . . . 51

Appendix C: Final Notes and Disclaimers . . . 52

WELCOME

Start Here

Who this is for, what you will get, and how to use it.

Every tree that comes down leaves a stump. Most homeowners do not want to look at it, mow around it, or trip over it, and they cannot remove it themselves. That is the entire business: you show up with a machine, grind the stump below ground level, clean up, and get paid for a job that often takes a few hours.

This playbook is written for **complete beginners**. You do not need to know anything about trees, equipment, or running a business. Every term is explained in plain English, every chapter ends with the next action to take, and the order of the chapters is the order you should do things in.

Is this playbook for you?

- People who want to escape the 9-to-5 and build a real, hands-on business.
- Anyone looking for a profitable blue-collar service with low startup costs compared with other trades.
- Side hustlers who want to start part-time and keep their job until the numbers prove the business.
- Tree service workers, landscapers, and contractors adding stump grinding as an extra revenue stream.
- New grinder owners who have the machine but no pricing or marketing system.

It is not for you if you want money without physical work, or if you are not willing to follow safety rules. Stump grinding is physical, it carries real risk if you ignore safety, and results are never guaranteed. This playbook gives you the system. You do the work.

What you get inside

PART	WHAT YOU LEARN	CHAPTERS
Prove it	How the business makes money and how to test your local market for under $100 before buying anything big	1, 2
Set up	Paperwork, insurance, equipment, safety, with three budget paths to start	3, 4, 5
Price it	A pricing method you can run in minutes, plus wholesale pricing for contractors	6
Get customers	Exact outreach scripts for tree companies, plus Google, neighborhoods, and reviews	7, 8
Win and do the job	Quoting, selling, objections, a repeatable on-site routine, cleanup, upsells	9, 10, 11
Grow	Systems, hiring, and a checkpoint for when to go full-time	12

PART	WHAT YOU LEARN	CHAPTERS
Launch	A 7-day first-job plan, a 30-day action plan, and a worked example of the numbers	13, 14
Answers	Common questions and the beginner mistakes that cost the most	15

What level is this playbook?

Beginner. It assumes you know nothing about stump grinding. Where a topic is advanced (hiring employees, a second machine, a bigger fleet), it is clearly marked and saved for Chapter 12 so it does not overwhelm your first 30 days.

Five rules for beginners

1. **Do things in order.** Chapters 1 to 6 before you spend serious money.
2. **Test before you buy.** Prove there is demand in your town for under $100 first (Chapter 2).
3. **Insurance and 811 before your first cut.** No exceptions.
4. **Price from your own costs**, not from a stranger's number.
5. **Get the first jobs from contractors** (Chapter 7). One tree company can send you work every week.

HOW THIS EDITION WAS CHECKED

Prices, tools, and rules were cross-checked in November 2026 against public U.S. sources: consumer price guides, state 811 centers, the IRS, the FTC, Google's policies, and trade safety groups. Rules still differ by state and town, so keep checking the VERIFY LOCALLY notes.

A NOTE ON NUMBERS

Every dollar figure in this playbook is an **example or a starting point** to help you build your own numbers. Prices, insurance costs, equipment costs, and legal requirements differ by state and by town. Nothing here is a promise of income. Where you see **VERIFY LOCALLY**, check with a local source before you rely on it.

How to use the companion files

FILE	WHAT IT IS	USED IN
Pricing & Business Calculator (.xlsx, works in Google Sheets)	Quote calculator, job profit, break-even, job tracker	Chapters 4, 6, 12, 14
Templates & Scripts Pack (.docx)	Quote, invoice, agreement, checklists, call and text scripts, post bank, outreach messages	Chapters 5 to 11

Wherever you see **USE THE TOOL**, open the matching file. If you bought the Playbook Only version, you can still follow every chapter and use your own spreadsheet. All key scripts are also written out in full inside this book.

CHAPTER 1

01 How Stump Grinding Makes Money

The business in plain English, before you spend a dollar.

1.1 What happens on a typical job

1. A homeowner (or a tree company) has a stump they want gone.
2. You get photos and details by phone or text, then send a written quote.
3. They accept. You call 811 so public underground lines get marked (free).
4. You arrive with a grinder on a trailer, grind the stump to about six to twelve inches below ground, and clean up.
5. You collect payment, ask for a review, and ask who else nearby has a stump.



A small-to-medium residential stump is often a one-to-two-hour job once you are on site. The rest of your time goes to driving, setup, cleanup, and paperwork. That is why **every** price in this book accounts for more than just grinding time.

1.2 Where the money comes from

CUSTOMER TYPE	WHAT THEY WANT	HOW YOU EARN
Homeowners	One to several stumps gone, lawn restored	Retail price per stump, with multi-stump discounts
Tree removal companies	A reliable specialist so they can take the next tree job	Repeat wholesale work; the most consistent source for beginners
Landscapers and lawn crews	Stumps cleared before projects	Repeat work and referrals
Realtors, stagers, property managers, HOAs	Fast curb-appeal fixes, a vendor with insurance	Batches of stumps across properties

CUSTOMER TYPE	WHAT THEY WANT	HOW YOU EARN
Fence, deck, and pool contractors	Stumps out of the way before installs	Pre-project jobs

1.3 Why it suits beginners

- **Low barrier to entry.** Compared with full tree service, the equipment list is short: one machine, a trailer, and a truck.
- **Fast jobs, clear scope.** The customer can see exactly what they are paying for.
- **Strong referral channels.** Tree companies and landscapers often prefer to hand stump work to a specialist.
- **Add-on potential.** You are already on site with a machine and a truck, and neighbors have stumps too.

1.4 The honest downsides

- It is physical work, and the machine is dangerous if you ignore safety.
- Income depends on your market, your pricing, your equipment costs, and how consistently you market.
- Weather and seasons affect your calendar.
- Equipment wears: teeth, belts, and repairs are real recurring costs.

1.5 Plain-English glossary (the words you will hear first)

TERM	MEANING
Grade	The level of the ground around the stump
Below grade	Ground out to below that level, usually six to twelve inches
Cutter wheel	The spinning wheel with carbide teeth that does the grinding
Root flare	The widening at the base where roots begin; adds work
811	The U.S. number you call before digging so public utility lines are marked, free
COI	Certificate of insurance: a one-page proof of coverage that customers and partners ask for
Subcontract	When a tree company hires you to grind stumps on their jobs
Minimum job fee	The lowest price you will accept for any job

Do this next

- The business is simple: remove stumps, clean up, get paid. The skill is pricing, safety, and finding jobs.
- Contractors who need a stump specialist are your fastest path to steady work.
- Know the downsides up front so nothing surprises you later.

CHAPTER 2

02 Prove the Idea for Under $100

Test your local market before you spend a dime on equipment.

The biggest beginner mistake is buying a $15,000 machine first and hoping customers appear. Do the opposite. Spend a few days and under $100 proving that stumps in your area are being ground, that people pay real prices for it, and that tree companies would hand you work. Then buy equipment with confidence.

2.1 The five-test market check

TEST 1: COUNT THE COMPETITION (FREE)

Search Google Maps for *stump grinding near me* and for the nearest three towns. Write down how many businesses appear, how many reviews they have, and whether they look busy. A few busy competitors usually means real demand. Zero results can mean opportunity or no demand, so run the other tests before you decide.

TEST 2: BE A MYSTERY SHOPPER (FREE)

Call or message three to five local operators as a customer. Say you have two stumps, 14 and 20 inches. Ask for a price, how fast they can come, and what is included. Write down every answer. This tells you the local price range, how slow competitors respond, and what you can do better.

> **MYSTERY SHOPPER SCRIPT**
>
> *"Hi, I have two stumps in my backyard, about 14 and 20 inches across. What would you charge to grind them, and how soon could you come? Does that include cleanup of the chips?"*

TEST 3: ASK THE CONTRACTORS (FREE)

Call five local tree removal companies and landscapers. Ask one question: do you grind your own stumps, or do you hand them off? Count how many say they hand them off or would like someone reliable. Two or three yeses is a strong sign.

> **CONTRACTOR QUESTION SCRIPT**
>
> *"Hi, I am looking at starting stump grinding in the area. When you take down a tree, do you grind the stump yourselves or send it out? If you send it out, who do you use and how is that going?"*

TEST 4: CHECK COMMUNITY DEMAND (FREE)

Search your local Facebook groups and Nextdoor for *stump* over the last 30 days. Count the requests. Ten or more in a month across a few groups is a healthy sign.

TEST 5: RUN A WAITLIST TEST (ABOUT $30 TO $60)

Make a simple one-page website or Google Business Profile with a quote request form, order a small batch of door hangers or business cards, and post once in local groups: *Now booking stump grinding in [town], request a free quote*. Collect quote requests. **Do not accept paid work yet.** You are measuring interest, and you need insurance and equipment in place before doing a job.

2.2 Your under-$100 test budget (example)

ITEM	EXAMPLE COST	NOTES
Domain name and a simple one-page site	$12 to $30	Free site builders exist; the domain is the main cost
Business cards or door hangers (small batch)	$20 to $40	Online printers are cheap for 100 to 250
Google Business Profile	$0	Free
Local group posts and calls	$0	Your time only
Mystery shopping and contractor calls	$0	Phone minutes
Total	**Under about $100**	Prices are examples; check current rates

2.3 Your go / no-go scorecard

QUESTION	YES?
Are there at least a few competitors with real reviews, or clear unmet demand?	☐
Do local prices (mystery shopping) look high enough to leave profit after costs?	☐
Did at least two of five contractors say they hand off stumps or want a better option?	☐
Did you see roughly ten or more stump requests in local groups in 30 days?	☐
Did your waitlist test get quote requests?	☐

Four or five yes answers: go ahead to Chapter 3. **Two or three:** you can proceed carefully, probably by renting a grinder first (Chapter 4). **Zero or one:** widen your service area, test another town, or reconsider before spending money.

Why this chapter raises your odds

Most failed side businesses fail on demand, not skill. A one-week test costs almost nothing and tells you whether the market is there, what price people expect, and who your first customers might be.

Do this next

- Test demand before buying equipment.
- Mystery shopping tells you local prices and how to beat competitors on speed.
- Do not take paid jobs until insurance and equipment are in place.

CHAPTER 3

03 Set Up the Business

Name, paperwork, bank account, and the insurance questions most beginners forget.

A clean setup protects you personally and makes you look professional to customers, tree services, and property managers. None of this has to take long, but do not skip the insurance step.

3.1 Choose a name and structure

Pick a simple, local-sounding name that says what you do and where you do it. A name like *Riverside Stump Removal* works better than a clever one because customers search by service and town. Before you commit, check that the name is available in your state's business registry, that a matching domain is available, and that the social handles are free.

Most small operators choose either a **sole proprietorship** (simplest) or a **single-member LLC** (adds a layer of separation between your business and your personal assets). An LLC does not replace insurance, and rules, fees, and annual requirements vary by state. A local accountant or attorney can tell you what fits. The U.S. Small Business Administration (sba.gov) has free guides.

> **VERIFY LOCALLY**
>
> State LLC filing fees, annual report requirements, and any city or county business license you need. Search your state's Secretary of State website and your city or county business license page.

3.2 Basic registrations

1. **EIN.** If you form an LLC or plan to hire, get a free Employer Identification Number at irs.gov/ein. It is free, and you should never pay a third party for one.
2. **State and local registrations.** Business license, sales tax registration if your state taxes services like yours, and any trade-specific rules. Requirements for stump grinding are usually light, but check.
3. **Business bank account.** Open a separate checking account and use it for every business transaction. Taxes and bookkeeping become dramatically easier.

3.3 Insurance

Insurance is not optional. Grinders throw debris, equipment can strike buried lines, and customers expect a professional to carry coverage. Many tree services and property managers will not hire you without proof of

insurance.

COVERAGE	WHAT IT GENERALLY DOES	NOTES
General liability	Covers third-party property damage and injury claims from your work	The core policy; ask whether grinding and underground damage are covered or excluded
Commercial auto	Covers your truck when used for business	Personal auto policies often exclude business use
Equipment / inland marine	Covers theft or damage to your grinder and trailer	Useful once you own expensive equipment
Workers' compensation	Covers employee injuries	Often required once you have employees; rules vary by state

When you shop for quotes, ask each agent:

- Do you write policies for stump grinding or tree care specifically, or is this classed as landscaping?
- Does the policy exclude or limit damage to underground utilities, irrigation, or sewer lines?
- Can I get a certificate of insurance (COI) the same day when a customer or partner asks?
- What happens to my coverage if I add a helper?

> *Worth knowing*
>
> Get at least three quotes, including one from an independent agent who works with several carriers. Underground damage coverage is the question beginners forget to ask.

3.4 Bookkeeping and taxes in plain English

Track every dollar in and out from day one. At minimum, record the date, customer, amount, and payment method for income, and categorize expenses: fuel, teeth and wheels, insurance, repairs, marketing, and equipment. The Job Tracker tab in the calculator covers income; use a simple bookkeeping app or spreadsheet for expenses.

Self-employed operators generally owe self-employment tax on net profit, at a combined 15.3 percent for Social Security and Medicare, on top of income tax. The IRS expects quarterly estimated payments (Form 1040-ES) if you expect to owe $1,000 or more for the year. A good habit: move a set share of every payment into a separate savings account for taxes, and ask your accountant what share fits you. Talk to a local accountant early. It is cheap compared with fixing a mess later.

> **NOT TAX OR LEGAL ADVICE**
>
> This playbook explains common practices. It is not tax, legal, or insurance advice. Talk to a licensed professional in your state before making decisions.

Do this next

- Open a separate business bank account on day one.
- Get liability insurance before your first job, and ask about underground damage coverage.
- Check state and local licensing instead of assuming.

CHAPTER 4

04 Equipment and Startup Costs

Match the machine to the work, pick a budget path, and know your real consumable costs.

Your grinder is the largest purchase you will make, and the wrong choice can slow you down for years. This chapter helps you match the machine to the work you actually plan to do, and gives you three ways to start at different budgets.

4.1 Types of stump grinders

TYPE	BEST FOR	STRENGTHS	TRADE-OFFS
Walk-behind (hand-guided)	Beginners; yards with gates and fences	Lower cost, easy to transport, fits narrow access	More physical effort; slower on large stumps
Self-propelled / tracked	Several stumps per week	Better on slopes and soft ground, less fatigue, handles bigger stumps	Higher price; heavier to transport
Skid-steer or tractor attachment	Operators who already own a skid steer	Powerful, fast on large stumps	Needs the host machine; less maneuverable
Large trailer-mounted / commercial	High-volume commercial work	Very fast on large or multiple stumps	Significant cost and towing requirements

> *Rule of thumb*
>
> Match the machine to the stumps you will see most often, not the biggest one you can imagine. Most residential work is small-to-medium stumps in yards with gates, fences, and slopes. If you cannot get your machine through a typical backyard gate, you will turn down jobs.

4.2 Three ways to start (pick one)

PATH	HOW IT WORKS	PROS	CONS
A. Rent first	Rent a grinder by the day from an equipment rental store for your first jobs	Lowest risk; learn technique and test demand; no large purchase	Costs more per job; availability and tow logistics; rental prices vary

PATH	HOW IT WORKS	PROS	CONS
B. Buy used	Buy a used walk-behind or smaller self-propelled machine after inspection	Far lower cost than new; faster payback	Higher repair risk; inspection is essential
C. Buy new (or financed)	New machine from a dealer, possibly with financing	Warranty, reliability, dealer support	Biggest cost; financing adds interest and monthly payments

> *What rental really costs*
>
> Public price guides in 2026 put typical grinder rental at roughly $100 to $400 per day, depending on the machine and the store, with mini or walk-behind units at the low end and larger tow-behind or self-propelled units higher. Call two or three local rental shops, and ask about delivery, fuel, and damage waivers.

A NOTE ON FINANCING (VERIFY LOCALLY)

Prices swing widely: a day of rental, a small or used machine, and a new professional unit are very different spends. Many dealers and equipment lenders offer financing. Before you sign anything, work out the monthly payment and compare it with your realistic monthly profit (Chapter 14). Ask about the interest rate, the term, the down payment, and what happens if you miss a payment. As a beginner, a payment you can cover even on a slow month is far safer than the biggest machine you can qualify for. Talk to your accountant or a trusted advisor before borrowing.

4.3 Example startup cost ranges

These are illustrative categories to help you plan. Get real quotes locally.

ITEM	RENT-FIRST PATH	USED PATH	NEW PATH
Grinder	Day rental per job	Used machine after inspection	New machine or financing payment
Truck and trailer	Use what you have if it can tow safely	Used trailer if needed	May need new trailer and hitch upgrades
Insurance	Required before any job	Required	Required
PPE and hand tools	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spare teeth and fluids	Rental covers machine	Stock a spare set	Stock a spare set
Marketing basics	Under $100 to start	Under $100 to start	Under $100 to start

Use the **BreakEven tab** in the calculator: enter what you plan to spend and your average profit per job, and it shows how many jobs and months it takes to get your money back. If the answer is longer than you are comfortable with, choose a cheaper path.

4.4 Questions to answer before you buy

1. What gate width and access conditions are common in my market?
2. What is the largest stump diameter I expect to handle routinely?
3. What can my truck legally and safely tow, including the trailer and machine weight?
4. Can I get parts, teeth, and service locally or by quick shipping?
5. How many jobs per week do I realistically expect in my first three months?

4.5 Inspecting a used grinder

- **Cutter wheel:** wobble, cracks, bent or missing tooth pockets.
- **Teeth and holders:** worn holders are expensive to replace.
- **Engine:** cold-start it, listen for knocking, check oil, look for smoke or leaks.
- **Hydraulics (if equipped):** leaks at hoses and fittings.
- **Belts, clutch, and drive components:** slipping or heavy wear.
- **Frame and welds:** cracks, repairs, bent members.
- **Tracks or tires:** wear and condition.
- **Safety guards and shields:** all present and intact.
- **Hour meter and service history:** ask for records.
- **Serial number:** confirm the machine is not reported stolen and the seller has title or proof of ownership.

> *Worth knowing*
>
> Bring someone who knows small engines, or pay a local shop to inspect before you buy. A few hundred dollars for an inspection can save thousands.

4.6 Truck and trailer

- Know your truck's towing capacity and the trailer-plus-machine weight. Do not guess.
- Use a proper hitch, safety chains, and trailer brakes as required by law for your trailer's weight.
- Use ratchet straps or chains rated for the machine and secure it at multiple points.
- Check registration and any trailer inspection requirements in your state.

4.7 Teeth, wheels, and consumables

The cutting teeth are your biggest recurring cost. Sharp teeth cut faster, use less fuel, and put less strain on the machine. Dull teeth slow you down and waste money.

- Keep a spare set of teeth and the correct wrench and hardware in the truck.
- Rotate or replace teeth according to the manufacturer's guidance; do not wait until the wheel is damaged.

- Track how many jobs you get from a set so you can build the cost into your pricing (the JobProfit tab has a field for this).
- Buy from a reputable supplier; cheap teeth that fail early can damage the wheel.

STARTER KIT ITEM	WHY
Spare teeth and hardware	Prevent downtime mid-job
Engine oil, filters, hydraulic fluid (if applicable)	Routine maintenance
Fuel can and funnel	Refueling on site
Hand tools, wrenches, grease	Quick fixes and daily maintenance
Shovel, rake, wheelbarrow or tarp	Cleanup and moving chips
Probe bar or digging bar	Checking for rocks and metal near the stump
Marking paint or flags	Marking utility locations and hazards

Do this next

- Pick a start path that fits your budget: rent, used, or new.
- Buy for the stumps you will see most, not the biggest imaginable.
- Inspect used machines carefully, and track teeth cost per job from day one.

CHAPTER 5

05 Safety

PPE, work zones, and calling 811 before every single job.

A stump grinder is a spinning wheel of carbide teeth that throws wood, dirt, and sometimes rocks. Most injuries come from rushing, skipping gear, letting bystanders stand too close, or not knowing what is underground. Your first job is to go home in the same condition you left.

ALWAYS FOLLOW YOUR MANUAL

The operator's manual for your specific machine is the authority on its safe use. Read it cover to cover before you grind your first stump. This chapter covers general good practice and does not replace the manual or any training.

5.1 Personal protective equipment (PPE)

PROTECTION	WHY	EXAMPLES
Eye and face	Chips and debris fly at high speed	Safety glasses plus a face shield or mesh visor
Hearing	Grinders are loud enough to damage hearing over time	Earmuffs or rated earplugs
Head	Overhead branches and flying debris	Hard hat if working near trees or overhead hazards
Hands	Cuts, vibration, and grip	Snug-fitting work gloves; no loose cuffs or dangling straps
Legs	Debris and accidental contact	Long, sturdy pants; consider chainsaw-style chaps if your manual or insurer recommends
Feet	Dropped tools and flying debris	Steel- or composite-toe work boots
Lungs	Fine dust and mold in old stumps	Dust mask or respirator suited to the conditions

5.2 Set up a safe work zone

- Walk the entire area before starting and note fences, windows, vehicles, play equipment, pets, and people.

- Keep bystanders, children, and pets far outside the debris zone. Trade safety guidance (for example from the Tree Care Industry Association) commonly puts this at 50 to 75 feet while the wheel is turning. Your manual sets the minimum; when in doubt, use the bigger distance.
- Move or cover vehicles, windows, and fragile items. Hang a tarp or use a debris shield where needed.
- Tell the customer where to stand, and ask them to keep everyone inside while you work.
- Never operate the machine if someone enters the work zone. Stop the cutter wheel first.

5.3 Utilities: call 811 before every job

Hitting a buried gas, electric, water, or communications line can injure you, cause an outage, and result in expensive repair bills. In the United States, you can dial 811 (or start at call811.com) to have public utility lines marked for free before you dig. Grinding removes soil and roots well below the surface, so treat every stump as a dig site.

1. Contact 811 (or your state's one-call center) with the exact address and work location. Do it every time, even for a yard you did last year.
2. Wait the legally required time before starting. Most states require two to three full business days, not counting the day you call, but rules differ. Do not assume small or shallow work is exempt.
3. Do not start until all utilities have responded and you have confirmed the marks match the ticket.
4. Keep a copy or photo of the ticket and the markings in the job file.

IMPORTANT: PRIVATE LINES ARE NOT MARKED

811 marks public utilities. It generally does not mark private lines on the customer's property: irrigation lines, invisible pet fences, landscape lighting wiring, private gas lines to grills or pools, and septic or drain lines. Ask the customer where they are, look for sprinkler heads and valve boxes, and keep grinding depth conservative near suspected lines. Your agreement should say how these are handled.

VERIFY LOCALLY

811 notification lead times, and how long marks stay valid. It varies by state: about 14 days in Texas and up to 45 days in Washington, for example. If your job slips past that, call again. Also check how your state defines excavation, and when in doubt call anyway. Search "[your state] 811 one call law" or visit 811beforeyoudig.com for state-by-state rules.

5.4 Before every cut

- Inspect the stump and surrounding soil for rocks, wire, nails, and metal.
- Probe the ground around the stump with a bar and clear any stones you can reach.
- Check the machine: guards in place, teeth tight, fluids and fuel adequate.
- Confirm your footing and your escape path.
- Review the plan with any helper and agree on hand signals.

5.5 While grinding

- Engage the cutter wheel only when you are in position and the area is clear.
- Sweep side to side and lower the wheel gradually. Do not force the wheel into wood.
- Stay alert for sudden changes in sound or vibration; stop and investigate.
- Never reach into the cutting area or clear debris while the wheel is moving or has not fully stopped.
- On slopes, position yourself uphill of the machine and use caution to avoid tipping or rolling.
- Take breaks. Fatigue makes mistakes.

5.6 End of day

- Shut down, wait for the wheel to stop completely, and remove the key or disconnect as your manual directs.
- Clean debris from the machine and check teeth, belts, and fasteners.
- Secure the machine for transport or storage and do a quick walk-around.

Daily equipment check

The Templates & Scripts Pack includes a one-page Equipment Daily Inspection Checklist and a Pre-Job Site Checklist. Print them and keep them in the truck.

Do this next

- Call 811 for every job and keep the ticket.
- Private lines are not marked, so ask and flag.
- Stop the wheel before anyone enters the work zone.

CHAPTER 6

06 Price It for Profit

A pricing method you can run in minutes, with a fully worked example and wholesale pricing for contractors.

Underpricing is the most common reason new stump grinders burn out. You can be busy and still lose money if you do not account for travel, fuel, teeth, insurance, and your own labor. This chapter gives you a system you can run in minutes, and shows you how to charge what you are worth without scaring customers away.

6.1 Know what your time is worth first

Before any formula, decide what you need to earn. Work backward in three steps:

1. **Pick a target profit per working hour** (including driving and cleanup). Be realistic for your market and your goals.
2. **Add up your real costs per job**: fuel, vehicle wear, teeth, insurance share, marketing share, and any helper.
3. **Price so the average job clears both.** The JobProfit tab does this for you.

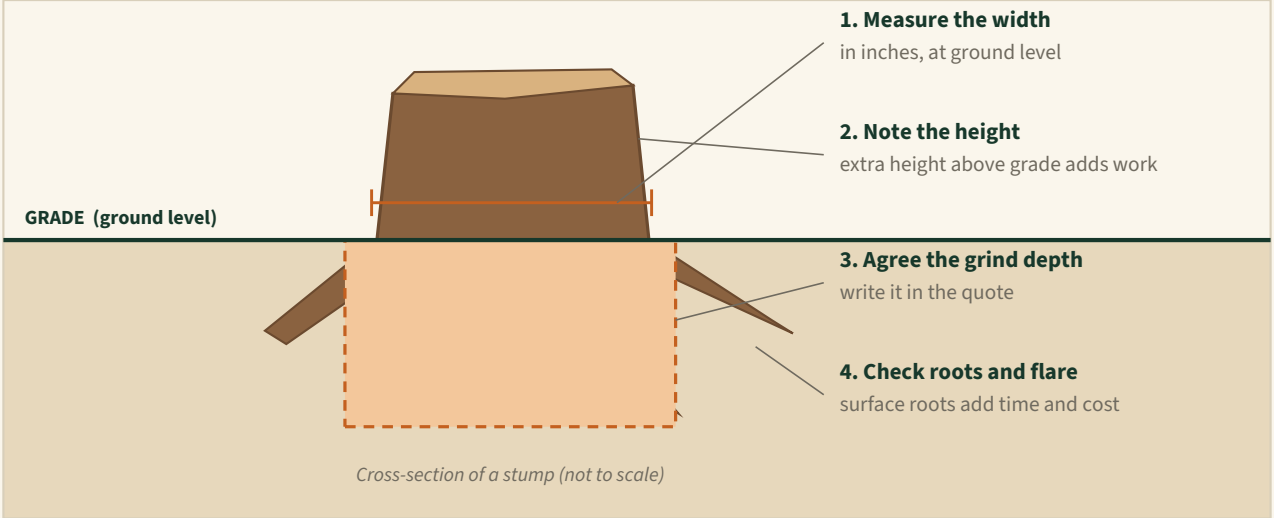
> *The two numbers that matter*
>
> **Profit per job** and **revenue per hour including drive time**. A job that looks big but sits two hours away may earn less per hour than a small job down the street. Track both from your first job.

6.2 Common pricing methods

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	PROS	CONS
Per inch of diameter	Diameter in inches x rate per inch (plus adjustments)	Simple, transparent, scales with size	Ignores access and difficulty unless adjusted
Flat price per stump	Set price by size bands (small, medium, large)	Fast to quote	Risk of underpricing larger or harder stumps
Hourly	Hours on site x hourly rate	Matches time spent	Customers dislike open-ended pricing; rewards slowness
Hybrid (recommended)	Per-inch base, adjusted for conditions, with a minimum fee	Fair, predictable, protects margin	Needs a calculator or sheet to stay fast

This playbook recommends the **hybrid** approach: a per-inch base, multipliers for conditions that add time or risk, a minimum job fee, travel charges, and a multi-stump discount. The calculator builds all of this for you.

6.3 How to measure a stump



- Measure the diameter in inches at the widest point, at or near ground level, including significant root flare where it adds work.
- If the stump is not round, take two measurements at right angles and average them.
- For a multi-trunk stump, measure each trunk and price accordingly, or treat it as a larger single stump.
- Note stumps that sit higher than a few inches above ground. Extra height adds work.
- Photograph every stump with a tape measure or ruler for reference.

6.4 Adjustment factors

FACTOR	WHY IT MATTERS	EXAMPLE MULTIPLIER
Hardwood	Dense wood dulls teeth and slows cutting	1.15 (softwood 0.90)
Heavy root flare / large surface roots	More material to remove	1.25 (moderate 1.10)
Tight access	Gates and fences slow setup and movement	1.15
Slope	Harder to position and operate safely	1.10 moderate, 1.20 steep
Rocks / metal risk	Tooth damage and risk; may warrant a waiver	1.15
Old, rotten, or very wet stump	Can be easier or messier	Judgment call

THESE MULTIPLIERS ARE PLACEHOLDERS

The numbers above are starting points, not market data. Use your mystery-shopping results from Chapter 2, call local operators for quotes on the same stumps, then set your own. Track actual time per job and adjust.

6.5 Minimum job fee, travel, and multi-stump discounts

Every job has fixed time: loading, driving, setup, cleanup, and paperwork. A single 8-inch stump takes nearly as much of your day as a 12-inch one. A **minimum job fee** ensures small jobs still pay for that time. Set it by calculating your cost on a small job and adding margin.

Add a **travel charge** beyond a free service radius (the calculator default is 15 miles, with a per-mile charge beyond it). Offer **multi-stump discounts** because you save setup and travel: for example 10 percent off for two to three stumps, 15 percent for four to five, 20 percent for six or more. Never discount below the point where your margin disappears.

6.6 Worked example

Starting-point settings: $4 per inch, $150 minimum, free travel within 15 miles, $3 per extra mile, 10 percent discount for two to three stumps.

STUMP	DIAMETER	WOOD	ROOT FLARE	BASE ($4/IN)	ADJUSTED
1	18 in	Hardwood (1.15)	Moderate (1.10)	$72.00	$91.08
2	14 in	Medium (1.00)	None (1.00)	$56.00	$56.00
3	24 in	Softwood (0.90)	Heavy (1.25)	$96.00	$108.00

STEP	AMOUNT
Stump subtotal	$255.08
Multi-stump discount (10%)	-$25.51
Travel (22 miles; 7 beyond free radius x $3)	+$21.00
Total before minimum	$250.57
Minimum job fee	$150.00 (not triggered)
Final quote (rounded to nearest $5)	**$250**

Now check the profit side. With two hours on site, one hour driving, and example costs for labor, fuel, vehicle, teeth, and overhead, this job comes to about **$144 in costs**, leaving roughly **$106 profit**, about **42 percent margin**. Your own numbers will differ, which is why you should plug in your real costs.

MARKET REALITY CHECK

National consumer price guides in 2026 commonly report about $2 to $5 per inch of stump diameter, minimum charges around $100 to $150, and typical single-stump jobs in the low-to-mid hundreds of dollars. The $4 per inch and $150 minimum used here sit inside that range, but your own market decides, which is why Chapter 2 has you mystery-shop local operators.

6.7 Wholesale pricing for contractors

Tree companies and landscapers will often send you repeat work, but they need room to earn on the job too. A simple structure:

- Offer a **contractor rate** that is modestly below your retail price in exchange for steady volume and easy scheduling (for example, a set percentage off retail). Choose a discount your numbers can survive.
- Keep a **minimum fee** for contractors too, so tiny stumps still pay for your drive.
- Offer **batch scheduling**: they send you a list of addresses, you group them by neighborhood. Grouping saves you drive time, which makes the lower rate profitable.
- Check each contractor job in the JobProfit tab. If a contractor's jobs consistently earn less per hour than retail jobs, adjust the rate or the minimum.

6.8 Quoting rules that protect you

- Quote in writing, with the number of stumps, grind depth, and what is included (chips, cleanup).
- State what is not included: backfill, seed, hauling away chips, repairs to unmarked private lines.
- Get a signed agreement or written acceptance before you start.
- Collect payment at completion, or take a deposit for larger jobs or long drives.
- If conditions change on site (hidden rocks, extra roots), tell the customer before continuing and adjust the price.

6.9 When to raise your prices

If you are booked more than a week or two out, or if almost everyone says yes to your quotes, you are probably too cheap. Raise prices a little and watch your close rate. Review pricing every quarter against your actual hours and costs.

Use the tool

Quote Calculator. Open the Quote tab, enter the stumps and conditions, and read the final quote. Keep your Settings tab updated so every quote uses your real numbers.

Do this next

- Use a per-inch base, adjust for conditions, and keep a minimum fee.
- Price from your own costs and profit-per-hour target, not from a stranger's number.
- Offer contractors a rate that rewards volume without erasing your margin.

CHAPTER 7

07 Land Your First Jobs: The Contractor Outreach System

Step-by-step: who to contact, what to say, and how to follow up until they say yes.

The fastest way for a beginner to get steady work is not ads. It is a handful of tree removal companies and landscapers who send you stumps every week. Tree crews cut trees all day and often do not want to deal with the stump. If you are reliable, insured, and easy to work with, they will call you.

7.1 The outreach system in six steps

1. **Build your target list.** Search Google Maps for tree service, tree removal, arborist, landscaping, and lawn care companies within about 30 to 45 minutes of you. Put 50 on a spreadsheet: name, phone, email, website, notes.
2. **Get your proof ready.** Your COI (certificate of insurance), a business card, and a before-and-after photo set (practice jobs on friends' or family's stumps, with permission, work fine at first).
3. **Send the first message** to ten companies per week using the scripts below.
4. **Follow up once** after two or three days, then once more a week later.
5. **Visit your best prospects in person** with a business card and your COI.
6. **Do a trial job.** Offer to grind one stump at your contractor rate. Do it perfectly, send before-and-after photos, and ask for the next one.

7.2 Scripts you can use word for word

> **FIRST TEXT OR EMAIL (SHORT)**
>
> *"Hi [Name], I run [Business Name], a fully insured stump grinding service in [Town]. I work with tree crews who would rather skip the stump on their jobs. I can usually quote from photos within a few hours and clean up properly. Would it help to have a go-to stump guy on your next job? I can send my insurance certificate and a couple of before-and-after photos."*

COLD CALL OPENER

"Hi, is this [Name]? This is [Your Name] with [Business Name]. I grind stumps in [Town] and I work with tree companies. Quick question: when you take a tree down, do you grind the stump or send it out? ... If you ever have extras or a backlog, I would love to be the person you call. I am insured, I quote fast from photos, and I leave the yard clean. Can I send you my details?"

FOLLOW-UP (2 TO 3 DAYS LATER)

"Hi [Name], just following up on my note about stump grinding. If you have a stump on this week's schedule, send me a photo and the address and I will quote it right away. Happy to send my insurance certificate too."

SECOND FOLLOW-UP (ABOUT A WEEK LATER)

"Hi [Name], last note from me. If you ever need stumps ground fast and cleaned up right, I am a text away at [phone]. I can start with a single stump so you can see how I work. Thanks!"

IN-PERSON DROP-IN

"Hi, I am [Name] with [Business Name]. I grind stumps and I work with tree companies in the area. I just wanted to introduce myself, leave my card and my insurance certificate, and say if you ever have a stump you do not want to deal with, I will quote it quickly."

PITCHING THE TRIAL JOB

"Why don't you send me one stump from your next job? I will grind it at my contractor rate, clean it up, and send photos. If you like how it goes, we can do more."

7.3 What contractors care about

- **Insurance.** Have your COI ready the same day.
- **Speed.** Reply to photos and requests within hours, not days.
- **Reliability.** Show up when you say you will, and text before you are late.
- **Cleanup.** Their name is attached to the yard you leave behind.
- **Simple pricing.** A clear contractor rate and minimum.
- **Fair dealing.** Never go around them to the homeowner for other work.

7.4 Track every conversation

COMPANY	CONTACT	DATE CONTACTED	FOLLOW-UP 1	FOLLOW-UP 2	TRIAL JOB?	NOTES
Example Tree Co.	Mike	Mon	Thu	Next Mon	Booked	Prefers text

Aim for ten outreach messages a week and at least three in-person visits in your first month. In the Templates & Scripts Pack, the Outreach Messages file has more variations.

Why this works for beginners

Each contractor relationship can send repeat work, so one good relationship is worth many one-off homeowner ads. Outreach also costs almost nothing but your time.

Do this next

- Make a list of 50 contractors and message ten per week.
- Follow up twice, then visit your best prospects with your COI.
- Win them with a clean trial job, fast replies, and insurance on hand.

CHAPTER 8

08 More Ways to Get Customers

Google, local SEO, neighborhoods, social groups, and reviews.

Contractors are your core. These channels fill the gaps and bring in homeowners directly. Pick two or three and run them consistently.

8.1 Google Business Profile (your best free tool)

When someone searches *stump grinding near me*, the businesses in the local map results get most of the calls.

1. Create or claim your profile at business.google.com and verify it using the method Google offers.
2. Choose the most specific primary category that matches your work and add secondary categories if they fit.
3. Set your service area by city or radius. If you work from home and do not serve customers at your address, hide your address as the platform allows.
4. Add a clear business description, phone number, hours, and website or booking link.
5. List your services: stump grinding, root grinding, multi-stump discounts.
6. Upload real photos: before and after shots, the machine, and your truck. Add new ones every few weeks.
7. Ask every customer for a review, after every job.

> **VERIFY LOCALLY**
>
> Google changes categories, verification rules, and features. Follow current prompts in your dashboard. Do not use a fake address or fake reviews.

8.2 Simple local SEO

- Build a one-page website with services, service area, photos, phone number, and a quote request form.
- Add a short page for each major town you serve, with real photos and details from jobs there.
- Keep your business name, address (if public), and phone number identical everywhere online.
- Get listed on a few trusted directories and your local chamber of commerce if there is one.

8.3 Other partners

PARTNER	WHY THEY SEND WORK	HOW TO APPROACH
Landscapers and lawn crews	Stumps block projects and mowing	Offer quick turnaround and clean results
Realtors and home stagers	Stumps hurt curb appeal before a sale	Fast scheduling and a before-and-after photo
Property managers and HOAs	Many properties, need a vendor	Provide a COI and a simple recurring-service offer
Fence, deck, and pool contractors	Stumps block installations	Offer pre-project stump removal

8.4 Door hangers and neighborhood marketing

- After each job, leave a short door hanger at the neighbors' doors: *We just removed a stump at [address]. Ask us about neighborhood pricing.*
- Do not put flyers inside mailboxes. U.S. federal law reserves mailboxes for postal items; use door handles or hangers.
- Check your city or HOA rules before distributing materials, and respect any No Soliciting sign.
- Park your branded truck where it is visible, with permission and safely.

8.5 Facebook, Nextdoor, and community groups

Local groups are full of people asking for tree and stump help. Participate genuinely: answer questions, share before-and-after photos, and respond to requests. Read each group's rules first, since many ban direct advertising outside designated threads.

- Create a Facebook business page and a Nextdoor business page.
- Post a job photo and a short story once or twice a week.
- Respond to requests within minutes. Speed wins.
- Use the Post Bank in the Templates & Scripts Pack for ready-to-edit posts.

8.6 Optional: short-form video

Short videos of grinding, before-and-after results, and quick tips can build local trust and attract leads. Geotag the town and mention your service area. Never film in a way that distracts from safety, and get the customer's permission before posting their property.

8.7 Reviews: the multiplier

- Ask every customer for a review, not only the ones who seem happy, and ask while the job is fresh. Asking only happy customers is called review gating, and Google prohibits it.
- Send a short text with a direct link to your Google review page.
- Reply to every review, positive or negative, politely and professionally.

- Do not offer discounts, gifts, or payment in exchange for reviews. Google prohibits incentivized reviews, and the FTC's consumer reviews rule (in effect since October 2024) bans fake reviews and paid reviews, with civil penalties for violations.

Goal for your first 90 days

Reach 10 genuine reviews, two active referral partners, and a completed Google Business Profile with at least 20 photos.

Do this next

- Finish your Google Business Profile before anything fancy.
- A few steady partners can outperform any ad.
- Never pay for or trade rewards for reviews.

CHAPTER 9

09 Quoting and Selling

From first call to signed quote, including what to say when they push back.

Most stump grinding customers are not shopping for the cheapest option. They want someone who answers quickly, shows up, explains the process clearly, and leaves their yard clean. Your sales process should make that obvious.

9.1 The first contact

Speed matters. Aim to answer every call, text, or form within 15 minutes during business hours. If you cannot answer, use a voicemail greeting that promises a callback time and send an automatic text. On the first call or message, collect:

- Name, address, and best contact number
- Number of stumps and approximate diameter of each
- Type of tree if known, and how long ago it was cut
- Access: gates, fences, and distance from the street
- Any irrigation, pet fences, lights, or buried lines they know about
- Photos of each stump with something for scale, such as a tape measure or shoe

> **FIRST-CALL SCRIPT**
> *"Thanks for calling [Business Name], this is [Name]. I can help with that. How many stumps do you have, and roughly how wide is each one? ... Is there a gate or fence I would need to get through? ... Do you know of any sprinklers, pet fences, or lights near the stumps? ... If you can text me a photo of each stump with a tape measure or a shoe next to it, I can send you a written quote today."*

> **PHOTO-REQUEST TEXT**
> *"Hi [Name], thanks for reaching out about your stump. Could you send two photos of each stump: one wide shot showing how I would get to it, and one close-up with a tape measure or a shoe for scale? I will send a written quote as soon as I have them."*

9.2 Quoting from photos

1. Ask for two photos per stump: one wide shot showing access, one close-up with a tape measure.
2. Estimate diameter from the photos, run the calculator, and send a clear quote.
3. Include what is covered, what is not, and a window for scheduling.
4. Confirm 811 timing and ask about private lines.

State clearly that a photo quote is based on the photos and may change if conditions on site differ.

9.3 The on-site estimate

For larger jobs or hard-to-judge stumps, a quick visit builds trust and prevents surprises.

1. Walk the property with the customer and note every stump.
2. Measure diameters and note roots, slope, and obstacles.
3. Ask where they want the chips, whether they want the hole filled, and whether they want seed or sod.
4. Explain the process: grinding depth, the chip pile, and what the area will look like afterward.
5. Give the quote on the spot or within a few hours, in writing.

9.4 Explaining what the customer gets

Many customers are surprised by the mound of chips and the shallow depression where the stump was. Set expectations up front:

- Grinding removes the stump to roughly six to twelve inches below ground level, depending on the agreement. This is usually enough for lawn restoration or planting a shrub.
- The result is a pile of wood chips and soil. You can leave it, spread it, or haul it away depending on the quote.
- Large roots may remain below the surface unless you agree to grind them out. Be specific about root grinding.
- If the customer plans to replant a tree in the same location, discuss grinding deeper or choosing a different spot.

9.5 Handling objections

OBJECTION	RESPONSE
“That’s more than I expected.”	Explain what the price includes: insurance, the utility locate process, cleanup, and travel. Offer a discount for multiple stumps, or reduce scope (leave chips, skip backfill) if appropriate.
“My neighbor’s guy charges less.”	“That’s possible. I price by stump size, and I carry full insurance and call 811 before every job. If another quote includes the same scope and cleanup, I’m happy to look at what they offered.”

OBJECTION	RESPONSE
“I’ll think about it.”	“Of course. I can hold this price for 14 days. Would it help if I sent the quote in writing so you can compare?” Follow up in two days.
“Can you do it for cash and no paperwork?”	Stay professional. “I give every customer a written quote and invoice; it protects us both.”
“Can you grind it deeper for free?”	Offer it as an add-on at a clear price, especially for replanting or construction.

QUOTE FOLLOW-UP TEXT

“Hi [Name], just checking in on the stump quote I sent over. I have openings on [day] and [day]. Want me to reserve one for you? Happy to answer any questions.”

9.6 Closing the job

- Offer two or three clear scheduling options.
- Ask for written acceptance via the quote template or a reply text or email.
- Confirm 811 timing, access, and any customer prep, such as moving vehicles and clearing the area.
- Send a confirmation message the day before.

Use the tool

Use the Quote Template, Service Agreement, and Invoice Template in the Templates & Scripts Pack. Edit your business details once and reuse them.

Do this next

- Answer fast. Speed wins most local jobs.
- Photo quotes save drives, but state they can change.
- Set expectations on chips, depth, and roots up front.

CHAPTER 10

10 Doing the Job

A repeatable routine from arrival to final walkthrough.

A smooth job is a repeatable routine. Follow the same steps every time and your results will be consistent, your customers will notice, and your risk will drop.

10.1 Arrival and site walk

1. Arrive within the agreed window. If you are running late, text before you are late.
2. Introduce yourself and walk the site with the customer. Confirm the stumps, the scope, and the quote.
3. Confirm 811 markings are present and match your ticket.
4. Ask again about irrigation, pet fences, lights, and other private lines. Mark them with flags.
5. Take “before” photos of every stump and the surrounding area.
6. Have the customer sign the agreement or confirm acceptance if you have not already.

10.2 Prepare the stump

- Cut the stump as low as practical if the tree service left it high. A lower start means less grinding.
- Remove rocks, wire, nails, or debris around the stump. Hosing off dirt at the base often reveals hidden stones.
- Probe around the stump with a bar to detect rocks and buried objects.
- Remove or protect nearby items, such as garden beds, statues, and vehicles.

10.3 Grinding technique

Technique makes the job faster, safer, and easier on your machine. Details vary by machine, so follow your manual, but these principles apply broadly:

1. Position yourself where you can control the machine and see the cutter wheel and the stump.
2. Start from one side of the stump, with the wheel just above the surface.
3. Sweep side to side in a controlled arc. Let the teeth cut; do not force the wheel.
4. Lower the wheel gradually after each pass, taking shallow bites rather than deep ones.
5. Work across the full width of the stump, then lower and repeat until you reach the agreed depth.

6 Grind the root flare and any exposed surface roots to the agreed extent.

7 Stop and reassess if you hear metal, hit a rock, or see sparks. Do not continue blindly.

WHAT THE CUSTOMER WANTS	COMMON GRIND DEPTH BELOW GRADE
Stump out of sight only	About 2 to 4 inches
Grass to grow back	About 5 to 6 inches, then fill with soil and chips
Plant a shrub or tree, or build, in the same spot	About 10 to 12 inches, or deeper if the machine can

> *Depth guideline*
>
> Most residential grinding lands between roughly 4 and 12 inches below the surrounding grade, depending on what the customer plans next. Always write the agreed depth in the quote, and stay conservative near suspected lines.

10.4 Dealing with problems

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Hidden rocks	Stop, remove if possible, or grind around. Inform the customer if it affects scope or price.
Metal (nails, wire, fence remnants)	Stop immediately. Remove what you can. Metal can seriously damage teeth and wheel.
Very large or numerous roots	Explain the added work and offer to grind roots at an extra charge, or leave them if the customer agrees.
Unmarked private line damage	Stop work, shut off the machine, keep everyone safe, and follow your agreement and insurance procedures. Document everything with photos.
Customer changes mind mid-job	Pause, restate the original scope, and agree on any changes in writing or by text before continuing.
Machine breakdown	Call the customer, reschedule, and avoid improvising dangerous fixes on site.

10.5 Cleanup

Cleanup is where good operators win referrals. Customers remember how the yard looked when you left more than how long the grinding took.

- Rake and shovel chips into a tidy pile, spread them thinly, or load them into your truck, per the agreement.
- Fill the hole with chips and soil if included, and tamp lightly. Leave a slight mound to allow for settling.
- Sweep or blow debris off driveways, sidewalks, and patios.
- Remove all flags and equipment.
- Check that fences, gates, and hardscape are clean and undamaged.

10.6 Final walkthrough and payment

1. Walk the site with the customer and confirm the work matches the agreement.
2. Take “after” photos.
3. Present the invoice and collect payment as agreed.
4. Ask every customer for a review while the job is fresh, using a text with a direct link.
5. Give them care tips: the area will settle, grass will need seed or sod, and wood chips can be used as mulch or composted away from the house.

> **REVIEW REQUEST TEXT**
>
> *“Thanks again for choosing [Business Name]. If you have a minute, a quick Google review helps a lot: [link]. Thank you!”*

Use the tool

The Pre-Job Site Checklist and Post-Job Walkthrough in the Templates & Scripts Pack keep you consistent from job to job.

Do this next

- Same routine every time: site walk, prep, grind, clean, walkthrough.
- Stop when you hit metal or unexpected conditions.
- Great cleanup is the cheapest marketing you have.

CHAPTER 11

11 Upsells and Repeat Business

Add-ons, referrals, and seasonal planning that raise your average job.

Once you are on site with a machine and a truck, small add-ons can raise your average ticket without much extra effort. Only offer what you can deliver well, and always quote it clearly.

11.1 Add-ons customers actually want

ADD-ON	IDEA	NOTES
Extra stumps	"Any other stumps while I'm here?" Offer a multi-stump rate	Best margin: no extra travel
Haul-away of chips	Charge for loading and disposal	Account for disposal cost and time
Chip pile left as mulch	Free or low-cost; saves your disposal time	Customers often like free mulch
Topsoil and grass seed	Fill the hole, add seed and starter fertilizer	Offer a finished-lawn price
Sod patch	Higher price for instant results	Only if you can source it locally
Root grinding	Grind visible surface roots	Quote by root diameter or length
Deeper grind for replanting	Grind below standard depth	Price as a premium

11.2 How to offer an upsell

> **UPSELL SCRIPT**
> *"Most people want the hole filled and seeded so the lawn grows back. I can do that for [price] while I'm here. Do you want me to include it?"*

11.3 Referrals and repeat work

- Ask every satisfied customer: "Do you know a neighbor or friend with stumps?" Leave a few business cards.
- Thank referrals with a clear, simple reward you can afford, such as a discount on their next job. Do not tie rewards to reviews.

- Keep a customer list and message past customers once or twice a year. Spring and fall are natural times.
- Stay in touch with partners. A quick text after each partner referral, with before-and-after photos, builds trust.

11.4 Seasonal planning

- Spring and early fall are often busy for outdoor work in many regions. Winter may be slow in cold climates; use downtime for maintenance, marketing, and partner outreach.
- After storms, tree services get busy and stumps pile up. Reach out to partners before storm season and let them know you have capacity.
- Frozen or very wet ground can affect access and cleanup. Plan scheduling accordingly.

Do this next

- More stumps on the same visit is the best-margin add-on.
- Ask for referrals while the customer is happy.
- Plan around your region's busy and slow seasons.

CHAPTER 12

12 Systems, Scaling, and Going Full-Time

The numbers to watch, simple scheduling, when to hire, and when to leave your day job.

Systems let you handle more jobs without more chaos. Start simple and add tools only when they solve a real problem.

12.1 Know your numbers

METRIC	HOW TO CALCULATE	WHY IT MATTERS
Profit per job	Revenue minus all costs including your labor	Shows whether pricing works
Revenue per hour (including drive)	Job revenue divided by total hours	Compares jobs and tells you which to avoid
Close rate	Jobs completed divided by leads or quotes	Shows whether your sales process works
Cost per lead	Marketing spend divided by leads	Shows which channels deserve more effort

The JobProfit and Tracker tabs calculate these for you. Review them weekly for the first three months.

12.2 Scheduling and routing

- Group jobs by neighborhood to reduce drive time and fuel.
- Book jobs in half-day blocks and leave buffer for surprises.
- Confirm every job the day before by text.
- Use a shared calendar and keep 811 ticket dates in the event notes.
- Do not stack too many jobs in one day. One equipment problem should not ruin the day.

12.3 Simple customer management

A spreadsheet is enough to start. As volume grows, a free or low-cost CRM or field service app can help with quotes, invoicing, reminders, and payment links.

- Save every customer's contact info, address, job notes, and photos.
- Record where each lead came from so you know which marketing works.

- Set reminders to follow up on unanswered quotes after 2 and 7 days.
- Tag past customers so you can message them seasonally.

12.4 Going from side hustle to full-time

The goal is not to quit as fast as possible. It is to quit when the numbers say it is safe. Here is a simple checkpoint list. Treat it as a guide, and talk to a financial professional about your own situation.

CHECKPOINT	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Consistent profit	Several months in a row where business profit (after paying yourself nothing and covering all costs) is a large share of your monthly living expenses
Demand	You are booked a week or two ahead and sometimes turning down work
Repeat sources	At least two or three contractor relationships that send work regularly
Cash cushion	Savings that cover your living expenses for several months, plus money set aside for taxes and equipment repairs
Systems	Quoting, scheduling, and invoicing run without chaos
Insurance and health plan	You have solved coverage you used to get from your employer

BE PATIENT

Plenty of operators keep their day job for months while the schedule fills in. Quitting early is a bigger risk than quitting late. Let the Tracker data make the decision.

12.5 When to hire help

A helper can speed up cleanup, handle chips, and improve safety by providing a second set of eyes. Consider hiring when you consistently have more jobs than you can handle, or when cleanup is eating your day. *This is an advanced topic; skip it until your first jobs are running smoothly.*

- Decide whether the person will be an employee or an independent contractor. Classification rules are legal and tax matters and vary by state; get professional advice first.
- Confirm workers' compensation requirements in your state and update your insurance.
- Train every helper on safety rules, PPE, and the work-zone procedures in this book before they touch equipment.
- Start with cleanup and support tasks. Do not let a new person operate the grinder until you have trained and watched them.

12.6 Adding a second machine or a new service

- Add a second machine only when you are consistently booked and turning away work.
- Consider a larger grinder if large stumps are a regular source of jobs, or a smaller one for tight yards.

- Natural add-ons include tree removal, brush clearing, land clearing, mulch delivery, and lawn restoration. Each brings new insurance, equipment, and training requirements.
- Do not expand until your core pricing and systems are solid.

12.7 Pricing check-ups

Review your pricing every quarter. Compare actual hours and costs with your quotes, track tooth wear, and adjust. Raise prices when you are booked more than a week or two out; that is a sign the market will bear it.

Do this next

- Review profit per job, revenue per hour, and close rate weekly.
- Quit your job based on the Tracker data, not on excitement.
- Get professional advice before hiring.

CHAPTER 13

13 Your First Paid Job in 7 Days, and Your 30-Day Plan

Quick-start checklist, then week by week from paperwork to paid jobs.

13.1 The 7-day first-job plan

This plan assumes you already ran the Chapter 2 test and have a rental, a borrowed machine, or your own grinder lined up. If you still need insurance or equipment, do those first. **Do not take a paid job before insurance is active.**

DAY	DO THIS
Day 1	Buy general liability insurance. Open your business bank account. Print your COI.
Day 2	Set your prices in the calculator Settings tab using your mystery-shopping numbers. Customize the quote and agreement templates.
Day 3	Finish your Google Business Profile with photos. Put up the one-page website and quote form.
Day 4	Send 10 outreach messages to tree companies and landscapers using the Chapter 7 scripts. Post in two local groups.
Day 5	Follow up with Day 4 prospects. Visit 3 in person with a card and your COI. Answer every lead within 15 minutes.
Day 6	Quote every lead from photos. Book your first job. Check 811 timing and schedule accordingly.
Day 7	Confirm the job by text, load the pre-job checklist, and prepare your PPE and spare teeth. After the job: photos, review request, referral ask.

REALITY CHECK

If 811 or your state requires a waiting period, your first job may start a few days after you book it. That is normal. Book early and plan around it.

13.2 The 30-day action plan

WEEK 1: FOUNDATION

1 Choose your business name and check availability.

2. Register your business, get an EIN if needed, and open a business bank account.
3. Get at least three insurance quotes and buy general liability coverage.
4. Decide on equipment: rent, buy used, or buy new. Run the numbers in the BreakEven tab.
5. Read your machine's manual cover to cover and arrange basic training if available.
6. Collect your PPE and safety gear.

WEEK 2: MARKETING BASICS AND PRICING

1. Set your prices in the calculator's Settings tab after calling several local operators.
2. Create your Google Business Profile and complete every field.
3. Build a simple one-page website and add a quote request form.
4. Customize your Quote, Agreement, and Invoice templates with your business information.
5. Make business cards, a door hanger, and a magnet or truck sign if budget allows.
6. Take sample before-and-after photos, even from practice jobs on friends' or family's stumps (with permission).

WEEK 3: OUTREACH AND FIRST JOBS

1. Send your first 30 partner outreach messages to tree services, landscapers, realtors, and property managers.
2. Post in local Facebook groups and Nextdoor, following each group's rules.
3. Answer every lead within 15 minutes.
4. Quote your first jobs using the calculator and templates.
5. Complete your first jobs with the pre-job checklist, 811 ticket, and post-job walkthrough.
6. Ask every customer for a review and referral.

WEEK 4: REFINE AND GROW

1. Log every job in the Tracker and calculate profit per job and revenue per hour.
2. Compare your actual time and costs with your quotes and adjust pricing.
3. Follow up with every unanswered quote and every partner.
4. Set up a simple weekly routine: marketing, quotes, jobs, bookkeeping, maintenance.
5. Set goals for the next 60 days: reviews, partners, jobs per week, and profit per job.

13.3 30-day checklist

DONE?	TASK
☐	Business name, registration, EIN, bank account
☐	General liability (and auto, as needed) insurance in place
☐	Equipment decided, inspected, and transport secured

DONE?	TASK
☐	PPE purchased; manual read; safety routine written
☐	Prices set in the calculator from local research
☐	Google Business Profile live with photos
☐	Templates customized (quote, agreement, invoice)
☐	30 partner outreach messages sent
☐	First 3 jobs completed and logged
☐	First 3 reviews collected

CHAPTER 14

14 Running the Numbers: A Worked Example

A transparent model so you can see how costs, jobs, and profit fit together.

READ THIS FIRST

Everything in this chapter is an **illustrative model built from the Chapter 6 worked example**. It is not a record of anyone's results and not a promise of income. Your costs, prices, job counts, and local demand will differ. The point is to show you *how to build your own projection* in the calculator.

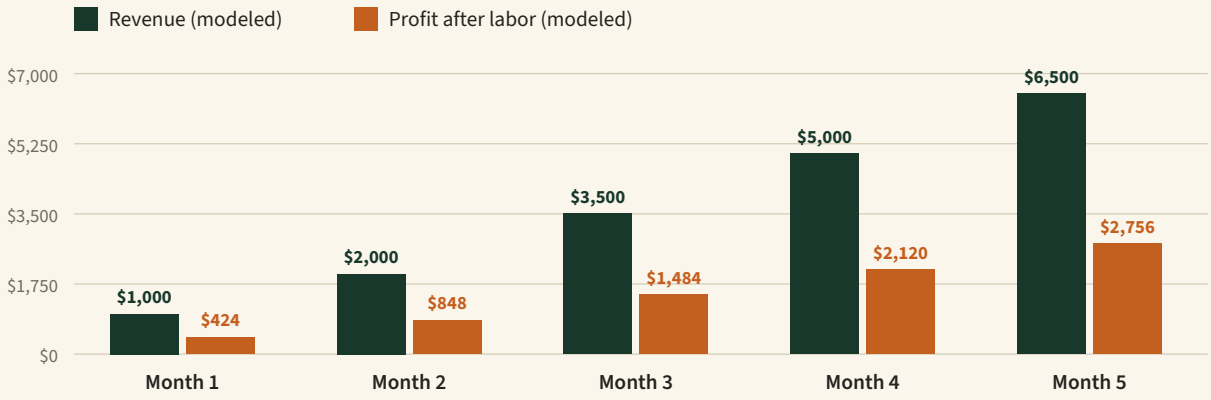
14.1 Per-job economics (from Chapter 6)

ITEM	EXAMPLE
Average quote	$250
Estimated cost per job (labor, fuel, vehicle, teeth, overhead)	about $144
Profit per job	about $106 (roughly 42% margin)

14.2 A modeled first five months (part-time start)

Assume you start part-time, grow your job count as your reviews and contractor relationships build, and keep the same average quote and cost. Profit here is **after** counting your own labor cost per job as in the example above, and **before** taxes and any equipment payment.

MONTH	JOBS (ASSUMED)	REVENUE AT $250 AVG	PROFIT AT ABOUT $106/JOB
Month 1	4	$1,000	about $424
Month 2	8	$2,000	about $848
Month 3	14	$3,500	about $1,484
Month 4	20	$5,000	about $2,120
Month 5	26	$6,500	about $2,756
Total	**72**	**$18,000**	**about $7,632**



These job counts are **assumptions** you can change. A slower ramp, or a higher or lower average ticket, gives very different results. Larger multi-stump jobs and contractor batches can raise the average; competition, weather, and slow seasons can lower it.

14.3 What to do with this model

1. Open the BreakEven tab and enter your own equipment cost, average profit per job, and jobs per week.
2. Compare your Month 1 to 3 actual jobs against the model. Are you ahead, behind, or on track?
3. If you are behind on jobs, increase outreach (Chapter 7). If you are behind on profit per job, check pricing and costs (Chapter 6).
4. Revisit the model every month with real data and rebuild the next three months.

14.4 Equipment payback check

If your machine and trailer cost a combined $21,000 (the example used in the calculator) and you earn about $106 profit per job, you need roughly 200 jobs to recover the cost before counting taxes, repairs, or financing interest. At 14 jobs a month that is about 14 months; at 26 jobs a month about 8 months. A cheaper used machine, or renting first, shortens the payback. This is why Chapter 4 offers three start paths.

Do this next

- Build your own projection from your own prices and costs.
- Treat any example, including this one, as a model rather than a promise.
- Check equipment payback before you buy.

CHAPTER 15

15 Common Questions and Beginner Mistakes

Quick answers, and the errors that cost new operators the most.

15.1 Questions beginners ask

DO I NEED EXPERIENCE?

No. You need to read your machine manual, follow safety rules, practice on a few stumps, and learn pricing. Practice on friends' or family's stumps (with permission) before your first paid job.

CAN I START WITH A DAY JOB?

Yes. Many people start part-time on evenings and weekends and keep their job until the Tracker data supports leaving (Chapter 12).

HOW MUCH MONEY DO I NEED TO START?

It depends on your path. Testing the idea costs under $100 (Chapter 2). Renting a machine keeps the upfront cost low. Buying new costs the most. Insurance is required in every case.

WHAT IF THERE IS A LOT OF COMPETITION?

Compete on speed, reliability, cleanup, and insurance, and lean on contractor partnerships (Chapter 7). Many competitors answer slowly and leave a mess.

WHAT IF MY STATE DOES NOT HAVE 811?

811 is the U.S. national number. If you operate elsewhere, find your local utility-locate service and follow it.

CAN I USE THIS PLAYBOOK OUTSIDE THE U.S.?

The business model and most of the process transfer, but licensing, insurance, utility-locate rules, and tax rules are different. Verify everything locally.

15.2 The ten most expensive beginner mistakes

1. Buying equipment before testing demand.
2. Taking paid jobs before insurance is active.
3. Skipping 811, or forgetting that private lines are not marked.
4. Underpricing, and not counting drive time, teeth, and your own labor.
5. Quoting without writing down scope, depth, and exclusions.
6. Skipping the minimum job fee.

7 Ignoring contractors and relying only on ads.

8 Poor cleanup, which kills referrals.

9 Not tracking profit per job and revenue per hour.

10 Quitting the day job before the numbers support it.

APPENDIX A

Quick Reference

Cheat sheet and pricing formula.

Pre-job essentials

- 811 ticket confirmed and marks match
- Private lines discussed and flagged
- Written quote and signed agreement
- PPE, spare teeth, tools, and probe bar loaded
- Customer informed about work zone and chip handling

Pricing formula (hybrid)

Final quote = [Sum of (diameter x rate per inch x wood x flare)] x access x slope x rocks, less multi-stump discount, plus travel charge, never below the minimum fee, rounded to your chosen increment.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Cutter wheel	The spinning wheel with carbide teeth that grinds the stump
Grade	The level of the surrounding ground
Root flare	The widening at the base of the trunk where roots begin
811	The U.S. one-call number used to request marking of public underground utilities
COI	Certificate of insurance, proof of coverage for customers and partners
Multiplier	A factor applied to a base price for harder conditions
Minimum job fee	The lowest price you will accept for any job
Close rate	The percent of leads or quotes that become paid jobs
Subcontract	When a contractor hires you to grind stumps on their jobs
Contractor rate	A reduced rate for contractors who send repeat work

APPENDIX B

Resources and Links

Real, free starting points. If a page has moved, search the site name.

RESOURCE	WHAT IT IS FOR	LINK
811 (Call Before You Dig)	Start a utility locate request and find your state's one-call rules	call811.com
IRS: Apply for an EIN	Get your free Employer Identification Number	irs.gov (EIN application)
U.S. Small Business Administration	Free guides on structure, licenses, and funding	sba.gov
Google Business Profile	Your free local listing for maps and search	business.google.com
811 state-by-state rules	Look up your state's notice period and rules	811beforeyoudig.com
FTC consumer reviews rule	What you can and cannot do with reviews and testimonials	ftc.gov
Tree Care Industry Association	Trade safety guidance for tree and stump work	tcia.org
OSHA	Workplace safety standards and guidance	osha.gov

Your companion files

Open the Pricing & Business Calculator to quote jobs and track profit, and the Templates & Scripts Pack for quotes, agreements, checklists, and messages. Both come with the Full Kit and the Calculator + Templates versions.

APPENDIX C

Final Notes and Disclaimers

Read this before you rely on anything in the book.

This playbook is educational and provides general information for people starting or growing a stump grinding business. It is not legal, tax, insurance, financial, or safety advice, and it does not guarantee any income or result. All numbers, including the examples and the modeled projection in Chapter 14, are illustrations. Laws, licensing, insurance requirements, utility-locate rules, and market prices vary by location and change over time. Always verify local requirements, follow your equipment manufacturer's instructions, and consult qualified professionals. Using any templates, scripts, or calculators is at your own risk; have a local attorney review agreements before relying on them.

Good luck, work safely, and price like a professional.